which brought together 5,000 delegates and 15,000 visitors from across the country, could not be clearer. Yet, Purshottam Das Tandon, a close confidant of Deputy Prime Minister Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, chose to 'preside' over the refugee conference.[34] In a ninety-minute speech, he made it clear that the Nehru–Liaquat Pact had 'failed to stop the migration of Hindus' from East Pakistan. 'Reports of dacoities in Hindu homes, molestation of women' and 'requisitioning of Hindu houses' were received 'even after the Pact', he added. This was precisely why Mookerjee had walked out of Nehru's government. Now a major Congress leader was publicly challenging the prime minister's flagship initiative. The conference concluded with a resolution on the 'Indo-Pakistan Agreement', which declared that Pakistan had failed to implement the Delhi Pact in its territory.[35]

Within two months, the sixty-eight-year-old Tandon defeated J.B. Kripalani, better known as Acharya Kripalani, in a contest for Congress presidency at the party's Nagpur session on 2 September 1950. Tandon's victory, by 1,306 of 2,618 votes, showed how deeply divided the Congress was on Nehru's refugee and Pakistan policy. The victory was construed in Congress circles as the 'most significant pointer to the Government as to the direction in which popular opinion in the country would like their policies and programmes to be reoriented in the coming years, particularly in regard to Indo-Pakistan relations, rehabilitation of refugees, propagation of Hindi and development of cottage industries'.[36] Kripalani later said that Patel had personally called several Congress chief ministers and solicited their support for Tandon's election.[37] Nehru, on the other hand, reportedly wrote a letter on the eve of the election to G. Ramachandran in which he 'strongly disapproved Mr Tandon's candidature'.[38]

When Tandon won, Nehru saw the election result for what it was: a direct challenge to his writ by the Hindu-traditionalist wing of the Congress. 'Communal and reactionary forces had openly expressed their joy at the result,' he responded in a bitter public statement, demanding a mandate for his policies from his party at its upcoming Nasik session on 20-21 September 1950.[39] The